ARCHAEOLOGICAL SURVEY OF INDIA
ANNUAL REPORT: ARCHITECTURAL HERITAGE DIVISION
SURVEY REPORT ON THE MONOLITHIC MONUMENTS OF ELLORA (CAVE 16)

Document Reference: ASI-WCR-1924-E16
Site Location: Aurangabad District, Maharashtra
Chronology: Rashtrakuta Dynasty, circa 756 - 773 CE (Reign of Krishna I)

I. EXCAVATION TECHNIQUE AND GEOLOGICAL CONTEXT
Cave 16, celebrated as the Kailasanatha (or Kailasa) temple, constitutes the zenith of rock-cut monolithic craftsm

The master craftsmen (sthapati) excavated three deep trenches at right angles into the hillside basalt, isolating a

ARCHAEOLOGICAL SURVEY OF INDIA - REPORT ASI-WCR-1924-E16 (PAGE 2)

II. ARCHITECTURAL CONFIGURATION AND ICONOGRAPHY

The temple manifests an elaborated Southern Dravidian architectural vimana plan. The complex comprises four

1. The Entry Gopuram and Gateway (Pratoli)
2. The Nandi Mandapa flanked by monolithic stone flagstaffs (dhvajastambhas) and life-sized guardian elephants
3. The Gudhamandapa (pillared assembly hall) resting on a colossal plinth carved with raging lions and mythical
4. The Garbhagriha (sanctum sanctorum) crowned with an octagonal Dravidian shikhara surrounded by five subs

The southern gallery features monumental sculptural relief friezes of the epic Ramayana, while the northern galle

III. EPIGRAPHICAL CITATIONS AND PLINTH INSCRIPTIONS
Comparative epigraphical evidence from the Baroda copper-plate grant of Karka II (dated 812 CE) corroborates t
'Oh, how was it that I could have built it without error?'

Later epigraphical records found on the ceiling corridors preserve inscriptions in old Kannada and Sanskrit chara